

FOOTBALL CRAZE

Nainamvalappu | KERALA



More than a game

A tiny town in the Kerala backwaters swears allegiance to football fields in a foreign land. Passions run high and arguments are intense as fans of Man U and Man City clash.

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Every August when the English Premier Football League kicks off far away in the sceptred isle, homemakers in Nainamvalappu, a coastal hamlet in Kozhikode, get ready to cluster around their television sets. The men and boys spend their nights at their club, the Nainamvalappu Football Fans Association, glued to the giant television screen at the local school. After the match they dissect every move and analyse every goal.

Like the time Manchester United played Manchester City in their city's face-off. The people of Nainamvalappu argue, and passions run high. Often even fights break out between rival clubs. "We did not show the match on the giant screen for there surely would have been bloodshed," says N.V. Subair, 30, the secretary of the club, recalling a match between Argentina and Brazil. The Latin American Football Association sends their publications free to the club. ESPN routinely features the fans and clubs in the district league are called

Barcelona and Chelsea. Their players wear their idols' jerseys and many are known by their names—be it Ronaldinho or Bianchi. Football is even more intense in neighbouring Malappuram, better known as Kerala's Brazil. The district has many football villages like Areacode known for their fanatic loyalty to clubs. "Here football is both a unifying and a divisive force. Football unites us across religious or political boundaries, but we also quarrel over it intensely," says Habib Rehman, an Areacode player.

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THE NUMBER OF
PROFESSIONAL
FOOTBALL CLUBS IN
KERALA

THE SPORTING LIFE:
Beach football in progress
near Kozhikode



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